

Seeing the signs

Drug use is problematic when a teen starts to need the drug in order to feel "normal." Addiction is when the cravings for the drug become so intense that a person feels they can't exist even a day without it. The following signs could indicate that a young person is developing a dependency on drugs.

Deteriorating
schoolwork

Taking drugs alone

Increased usage

Lying about how much
they've taken

Stealing money

PARENT TIPS

Talking about drugs

It can be worrying to know or suspect your teen is thinking about taking, or already taking, drugs. Talking about drugs is important, whether your teen is just curious, already using drugs casually, or you are concerned they are becoming dependent.

- Try to understand why your teen is using or wants to use drugs and discuss these reasons with them.
- Let them know you love them unconditionally.
- Listen to your teen and talk to them in a calm, nonjudgmental manner.
- Know where to find additional support if you feel out of your depth.
- Be informed about drugs to avoid giving your teen false or misleading information.

Getting help

It takes courage for someone to recognize and admit that they are dependent on drugs, but acknowledging the problem is the first step to recovery.

There are several treatment options available for those who want to stop taking drugs. A doctor can direct drug users to specialist counselors who can help make the transition to a drug-free life easier and more likely to last. Support groups provide safe spaces among other users where a person can discuss and reflect on their relationship with drugs.

▷ **Get the right help**
Coming off drugs can be hard, but there is guidance and support for those who need it.



GOOD TO KNOW

Drug withdrawal

Drug withdrawal describes the symptoms (both emotional and physical) experienced when someone who has taken a drug or drugs for a prolonged period stops taking them abruptly. Withdrawal is caused by decreased levels of the drug in the body's blood or tissues. Different drugs have different timelines of withdrawal symptoms. The symptoms of withdrawal can be life-threatening, so professional supervision is essential when stopping usage.